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Kratom Crazies: Hero complex and panic fuel poor legislation

Rep. Rob Beiswenger, District 8



IDAHO FREEDOM CAUCUS

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Kratom

Kratom (*Mitragyna speciosa*) is a tree in the coffee family, found in Thailand and neighboring countries. Traditionally, in Southeast Asia, people have chewed its leaves or made them into a tea that is used to fight fatigue and improve work productivity. Kratom has also traditionally been used during religious ceremonies and to treat symptoms such as pain and diarrhea, sometimes as a substitute for opium.

Two compounds from kratom, mitragynine and 7-hydroxymitragynine, interact with opioid receptors in the brain. People who use kratom have reported both stimulant-like effects (increased energy, alertness, rapid heart rate) and effects like those of opioids and sedatives

The media loves to manufacture a crisis and many politicians love to step in and save the day!

Today's example of this is the absolute hysteria over an Indonesian Kratom.

People in Idaho have been using Kratom for years and even decades for arthritis and pain management, but also mood enhancement or withdrawal.

But this 2026 legislative session the hysteria got so intense that a House member drafted a bill to ban natural leaf Kratom statewide, adding it to Idaho's Schedule One List alongside meth, heroin and fentanyl.

KTVB recently ran this sensational headline calling Kratom "Gas station heroin": ['Gas station heroin': Idaho family shares warning after mother died, linked to potent kratom compound | ktvb.com](https://www.ktvb.com/story/news/health/2025/08/14/gas-station-heroin-idaho-family-warns-after-mother-dies/8544444002/)

The article opens up with a sad story about a 50-year-old woman who reportedly died after taking Kratom. However, you don't have to be on the Health and Welfare Committee to know that medical issues are complex.

To its credit, the KTVB article states that Ms. Boswell struggled with alcohol addiction during her life. So, it seems logical that her body was weakened by those addictions over time.

But what a lot of people get wrong is Ms. Boswell did not, at all, take Kratom. She took a compound called 7-OH.

Now it is true 7-OH is a compound found in Kratom. Due to our technology we are able to isolate the chemical compound in a lab and put it in capsules.

Here's a question, did you know you can find cyanide inside apples and if you ate enough of them eventually it would make you sick and die.

But you probably wouldn't ask your State Representative to draft legislation to ban apples from the grocery store over it.

What was hard for me to understand in the Committee hearing was why we wouldn't just propose a ban on 7-OH only. There seems to be wide agreement on that. But instead of taking the victory and removing (7-OH and station heroin) from the shelves, she pushed for an all-out ban on kratom as well.

The truth is Kratom has been available to the public for decades. During the hearing and in preparation for the hearing to ban Kratom and 7-OH, many people had taken natural leaf Kratom for up to 20 years without issue.

Why would we want to take natural leaf Kratom away from people who are helping?

Further, it is ironic that the people trying to ban Kratom highlight that withdrawal is very dangerous, and yet that is exactly what they want to do.

their ban.

And despite using that claim for political gain, proponents of the current kratom users nothing to help them withdrawal, effective out from under them with little warning.

There was a Senate bill sponsored by Sen. Tammy Nichols that v Kratom on a regulatory structure (like most other imported prod Kratom would be tested before distribution but the legislation w enough support before the session concluded.

Hopefully next January if the legislature takes up the issue we c emotional over-reaction and carefully listen to all sides.

By Rep. Rob Beiswenger, Republican, District 8, Member of the H Welfare Committee



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Loud mouth, wild eyed freshman 'Karen'... ignorant about kratom, com
benefits (and beneficiaries), just wanting to score political points... and
self-importance, as well as all that CONTROL that comes with being a

Please do all that you can to keep the stuff in Idaho!



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Linda 7d



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/ alone. Do not re
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becomes, regulate, test, tax. all government NON-FREEDOM. BTW, I do
never have, but I have a friend who does take it and it helps her anxiety
anxiety, I would use homeopathics, but to each their own

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